



Fishing with bait

Many birds eat fish, but the green heron is one of the few that catches them using bait. It scatters twigs, feathers, insects, and other small objects on the water's surface and then stabs any fish that arrive to take a closer look. The bird's behavior is even more remarkable because it seems to be learned—some green herons never acquire this special hunting technique.



Living lure

When young, a Mexican moccasin snake has a brightly colored tip to its wormlike tail. The snake coils up and dangles its lure above its body, wiggling the bait to entice prey closer. Birds fall prey to this venomous snake because they focus entirely on the yellow, moving tail. They fail to notice the rest of the snake, lying camouflaged against the forest floor.

Killer shot

The banded archerfish cruises in the shallows of mangrove swamps, looking to shoot down prey above the water. If it spots an insect on an overhanging leaf, it presses its tongue against a groove in its mouth and quickly snaps shut its gill covers. This forces a jet of water out through its mouth, which knocks the insect off its perch. From under water, the fish have a distorted view of their prey, caused by the light bending as it passes from air to water. However, archerfish are able to compensate for this when they take aim and can hit a target more than 6½ ft (2 m) away.

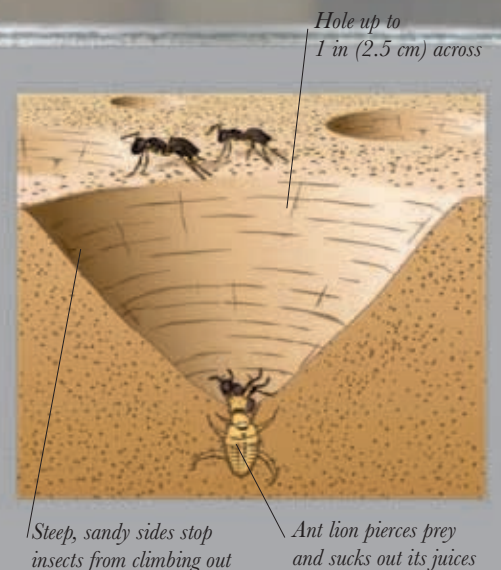


Gill cover closes rapidly, allowing fish to squirt jets of water

Water jet knocks insect down to waiting archerfish

Slippery slopes

In warm regions around the world, sandy ground is often peppered with small, steep-sided holes. These are traps dug out by ant lions—insect grubs that grow up to have long, lacy wings. Ant lions bury themselves at the bottom of the pit and wait for passing prey. If an insect walks near the edge of the hole, the ant lion flicks sand grains at it. The prey loses its footing and tumbles down into the ant lion's open jaws.



Hole up to 1 in (2.5 cm) across

Steep, sandy sides stop insects from climbing out

Ant lion pierces prey and sucks out its juices